

SIPRA DAS



MANMOHAN AND SONIA (LEFT) ADDED TO THE CONFUSION CREATED BY ANTULAY (TOP)



Sounds of Chaos



The Congress finds itself in a bind trying to explain Antulay's remarks.

I think to err is human. The matter should be allowed to rest.

MANMOHAN SINGH,
Prime Minister

Questions about Karkare's investigations and the circumstances of his death are wrong and deeply regrettable.

P. CHIDAMBARAM,
Home Minister

Other senior leaders in the Congress will discuss this (Antulay's remarks).

RAHUL GANDHI,
Congress Leader

Just because someone from a minority community makes a mistake, you want him sacked?"

VEERAPPA MOILY,
Chief, Media Cell

What is wrong if Antulay asked for a probe? Imagine a nationalist and secular person like Antulay being called anti-national.

DIGVIJAY SINGH,
General Secretary



scion Rahul Gandhi.

The entire Antulay episode is yet another example of the Congress's unflinching faith in votebank politics. It had no choice but to come up with an anti-terror law despite the fact that during the debate on Prevention of Terrorism Ordinance in 2002, Sonia Gandhi had argued against the need for such a law stating that "we have enough special laws in the country". Post-Mumbai, as the BJP stepped up its soft-on-terror charge, the Centre was forced to rethink its stand. Even as it was praised for adjusting to the changing times, the only worry for some Congressmen remained the minority vote. That also is probably the reason why Antulay was not sacked. And could taunt Chidambaram by telling the media not to "read the five-page note like a national essay competition in English literature".

It is not Chidambaram but the prime minister who is brushing up his English, quoting poet Alexander Pope. But perhaps he has got used to the act of forgiveness. Antulay is not the first cabinet minister to embark on an agenda of his own. Earlier, Arjun Singh took the prime minister by surprise with his quota politics, while Patil had 10 Janpath's blessings to carry on as home minister until the bitter end. To err, as the prime minister said, is human. But to forgive such ministers is less than divine. ■